> approach. We were also well supplied with water, the country being traversed in all directions by rivers and streams. To counterbalance these advantages we were annoyed with shoals of locusts, which literally darkened the skies and kept up a perpetual buzzing and humming in our ears. The locust appears to be a favourite article of food with the Afghans, who roast it on a slow fire and devour it with eagerness. We could not bring ourselves to relish this equivocal dainty, even though our rations were not of the best or most varied description.[81]

On 18 July, Keane received two pieces of intelligence. Firstly, the Popalzai plot to open the city gates had been discovered, and Shuja's loyalists had been replaced with Ghilzai tribesmen loyal to the Barakzais. Secondly, it was learned that the Barakzais were preparing to make a strong resistance around Ghazni. The cautious Keane decided to pause to let the centre column led by Shah Shuja and Willshire's rearguard catch him up.[82] Having collected his forces, he then marched forward in close formation. By sunrise on the 20th, the minarets of Ghazni were seen rising over the scrub, and beyond them the massive fortress, one of the largest and most impregnable in Central Asia. 'Instead of finding it, as the accounts had suggested, very weak and incapable of resistance,' wrote Keane, 'a second Gibraltar appeared before us: a high rampart in good repair built on a scarped mound, flanked by numerous towers and surrounded by a well constructed [escalade] and a wide wet ditch. In short, we were astounded.'[83] The existence of such impregnable fortifications represented a major intelligence failure on the part of the British, and it was unclear what could now be done as the siege guns had been left 200 miles away with Nott in Kandahar. It was not possible for the invaders to move on, leaving the Ghazni garrison behind them to threaten their communications. Nor did they have the supplies for either a retreat or a long siege.

As had been feared, the garrison put up stiff resistance as soon as the British closed in. They harassed the advancing lines of sepoys with their cavalry and outgunned them with heavy fire from the ramparts as the invaders attempted to take up positions around the fortress. 'The enemy came out in great force,' remembered Sita Ram, 'and sharp firing took place. The Afghans felt confident in the strength of this place. The walls were too high to scale and our light horse artillery guns were of no use against them. This was the first time we had any fighting since we entered Afghanistan.'[84]

This was also the first time the Afghans showed the accuracy of their long-barrelled jezails, the sniper-rifle of the nineteenth century, as their